negotiations continued along the same path as they had under the ex-viceroy's direction.

In fact, it was in this same month that Reading took office in Delhi that the Indian government heard encouraging news from Kabul. Since the Rawalpindi negotiations in 1919, the Indian delegation had been trying to uncouple Afghanistan from Soviet Russia, constantly intimating to the emir that the Bolshevik regime could not be trusted. In March 1921, Dobbs even presented Amanullah with information gathered by British intelligence demonstrating the duplicity of the Bolsheviks towards Afghanistan.[107] (Likewise, when news had reached Malleson in Meshed that the Afghans had sent letters and presents to the anti-Bolshevik rebels of Ferghana, he made sure to let the Soviet government know.)[108]

These attempts to drive a wedge between the two countries appeared to have finally succeeded when, on 12 April, Dobbs reported that the Afghans wanted to comply with Britain's wishes, but could only risk throwing over the Soviets if they could get reassurance of support against any backlash from Moscow.[109] Two days later, Dobbs repeated a conversation he had had with Amanullah, who had admitted plainly that he had tied himself up with the Bolsheviks because Britain would not make friendship quickly enough and that he was now in a mess.[110] By 20 April, the Afghan government was apparently very doubtful that it could ratify the agreement with Soviet Russia, since the latter was not sincere in its promise of not interfering in Khiva's and Bokhara's internal affairs.[111] For, while Soviet Russia had orchestrated the removal of Khan Abd Allah and Emir Amil, it had always maintained that it had merely been helping the Khivan and Bokharan people to attain freedom from their autocratic rulers. Thus, article VIII of the Russo-Afghan treaty had recognised 'The actual independence and freedom of Bukhara and Khiva, whatever form of government may be in existence there'. Yet, throughout 1921 the Bolshevik government would gradually gain greater authority over the regimes in the two new Soviet republics, so that by 1923 Bokhara and Khiva had gone from subordinate allies of Soviet Russia to 'thoroughly controlled satellites'.[112] Unfortunately for Amanullah the phrasing of article VIII did not afford him much recourse to prevent Bolshevik actions in Central Asia. By April 1921 then, Mahmud Tarzi, the